AEP FROM ZERO • PART 2 • SPEAK TO YOUR CUSTOMER (AJO)

EPISODE 17

Build a Journey in AJO: Optimize, Action, Wait

How do you build a journey in Adobe Journey Optimizer (AJO) in 2026? In this AJO journey tutorial, Bloom builds its welcome journey step by step on the journey canvas: an audience qualification entry on a streaming audience, an Optimize activity in place of the removed Condition activity, one Action activity for the email, and a two-day Duration wait. You will learn Read Audience vs Audience Qualification, why journey conditions only see fields in the journey's data source and how audience

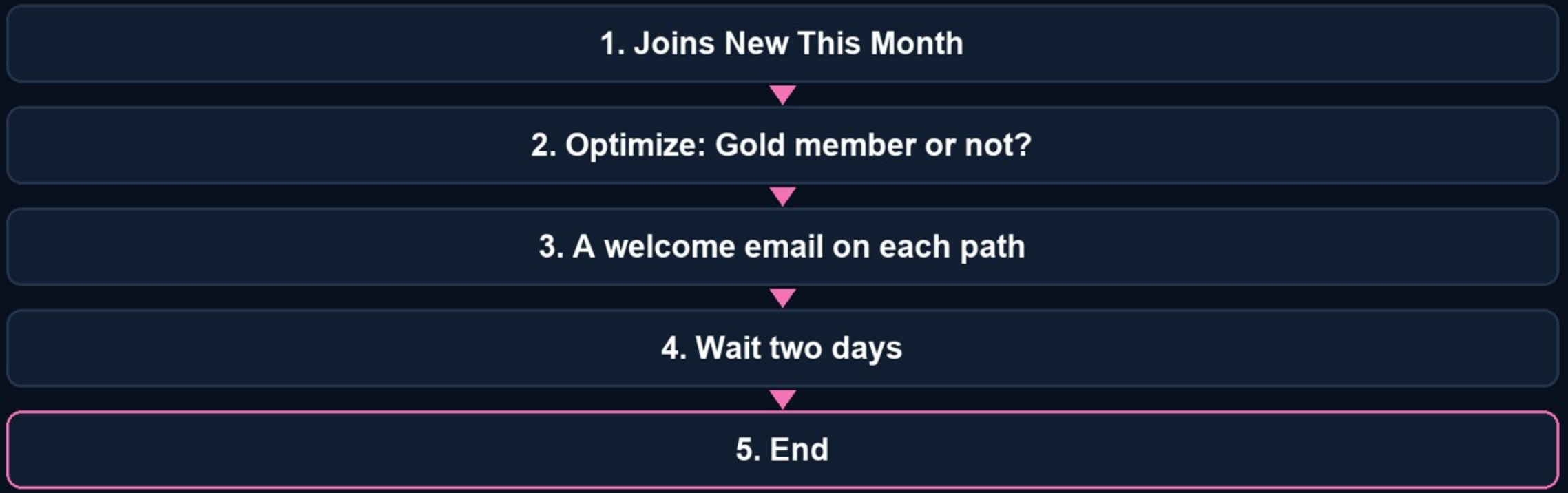
Previously: a deadline and a first rule

- Last time: campaign versus journey
- Gold Thank-You stopped at Review to activate
- Problem: new customers wait up to six days
- Goal: a welcome within a minute of a first order
- Today: build Bloom Welcome v1 on the canvas

KEY IDEA

Relaunch Monday is coming and Bloom's welcome still takes up to six days. Today Kavya and Divya build Bloom Welcome v1 on the journey canvas.

The blueprint on the whiteboard



KEY IDEA

Enter as someone joins New This Month, split Gold members from everyone else, send a welcome on each path, wait two days, then end.

A new journey opens with an alert

- Journey Management, then Journeys, then Create Journey
- Journey properties: name it, Save, status Draft
- Allow reentrance on; reentrance wait 5 minutes
- Toolbar: Alert (1), Simulate, Dry run, Publish
- Add steps with the plus: Events, Orchestration, Actions

KEY IDEA

Create Journey opens Journey properties and a canvas with only Start and End. Alert (1) shows at once, because the journey has no entry yet.

The entry: audience qualification

- If the moment matters, use an event
- If the state matters, use an audience
- First-time customer = joined New This Month
- Audience qualification: in as they join
- Streaming: near real time, no minutes figure

KEY IDEA

Audience qualification admits one person the moment they join an audience. On a streaming audience, that is how Bloom aims for a one-minute welcome.

Read audience versus audience qualification

	Audience qualification	Read audience
Who enters	One person as they join	Everyone in it, each run
When	The moment they qualify	Once, daily, weekly, monthly
Who gets in	Whoever joins or leaves	Realized profiles only
Where	The journey's entry	Only one, the first step
Best for	Real-time needs	Scheduled groups

KEY IDEA

Read audience reads an audience on a schedule: one per journey, first step, Realized profiles only. For real-time needs, use audience qualification.

Condition is gone: meet Optimize

- Condition: removed from the UI in 2026
- Replacement: the Optimize activity
- Default method: Data source condition
- Older journeys with Condition keep working
- Only the first true path is taken
- Order paths from most to least specific

KEY IDEA

Adobe removed the Condition activity from the journey canvas in 2026. Optimize replaces it, and its default method, Data source condition, does the same job.

Where are the loyalty points?

- Searched the editor for loyalty fields: nothing
- Journeys see only data-source fields
- ExperiencePlatform: name, address, email, phones
- Fix 1: an admin adds the fields (shared config)
- Fix 2: split on audience membership

KEY IDEA

Journey conditions only see fields an admin has added to the journey's data source. Bloom's loyalty fields were not there, so the journey could not see them.

The fix: split on Gold Members

Build Gold Members: tier = Gold

▼

Open Audiences in the editor tree

▼

Drag in Gold Members

▼

Membership is true: click Ok twice

▼

Tick Show path for other cases

▼

Gold path first, Others last

KEY IDEA

Divya built a small Gold Members audience, and Kavya split on its membership. The Gold path goes first; an Others path catches everyone else.

Other ways Optimize can split

Method	Splits people by
Data source condition	A field, or audience membership
Time or Date condition	Hour, day of week, or a date range
Percentage split	A random share, for tests
Profile cap	The first N people take this path
Audience	Membership of another audience

KEY IDEA

Besides a data source condition, Optimize can split by time, by date, by a random percentage, by a cap on the first N people, or by audience.

One Action activity, channel inside

Plus on the Gold path: Action

▼

Select action type: Marketing, Email

▼

Add; label it Gold welcome

▼

Configure action: channel config

▼

Edit content: placeholder for now

▼

Others path: Standard welcome

KEY IDEA

The separate Email, SMS and Push tiles are deprecated. You add one Action activity and choose the channel inside it.

The two-day Duration wait

Wait type	Use it for
Duration	A relative delay, up to 90 days
Custom	A date you calculate
Send-Time Optimization	Adobe picks each person's best time
Bloom Welcome v1	Duration, 2 days, then End

KEY IDEA

A Duration wait holds each person for a delay that counts from their own arrival. Bloom waits two days after each welcome, then the path ends.

Alerts: zero errors, one warning

- Alerts: top right of the canvas
- Errors must be zero to publish; warnings may stay
- Warning: the opt-out link is not present
- Two emails: it may be listed once per email
- The footer fragment fixes it in episode 19
- Status: Draft. Today's build ends here

KEY IDEA

Errors must be zero to publish; warnings may stay. Bloom Welcome v1 shows one warning: the opt-out link is not present in the email body.

Published by mistake? Close, do not Stop

Status	How you get there	What it means
Live	Publish	Real people enter; read-only
Paused	Pause	Nobody moves until resumed
Closed	Close to new entrances	No new entries; inside finish
Stopped	Stop	Everyone inside timed out
Finished	Automatic	Done; only now can be deleted

KEY IDEA

A Live journey is read-only. After an accidental publish, use Close to new entrances so those inside finish. Stop times everyone out.

Guardrails worth knowing

Guardrail	Limit
Activities in one journey	50, cannot be raised
Active journeys, development sandbox	100 (production: 200)
Longest stay, longest wait	91 days, 90 days
Read audience runs at once	5 per organisation
Journey payload	4.0 MB, shown in Journey properties

KEY IDEA

Journeys have hard limits: 50 activities, 100 active journeys in a development sandbox, 91 days per person, 90-day waits, 5 Read audience runs at once.

Interview corner

- No Condition in 2026: Optimize splits
- Order paths from specific to general
- Field not in the data source? Use membership
- Instant welcome: qualification plus streaming
- Mistaken publish: Close to new entrances

KEY IDEA

There is no Condition activity in 2026: split with Optimize, order paths from specific to general, and use audience membership when a field is out of reach.

Recap, your question, and the test buttons

- Instant: audience qualification, streaming
- Optimize replaced Condition; first true wins
- Missing field: data source or membership
- One Action; waits count from each arrival
- Next: which test buttons send real email?

KEY IDEA

Instant entry, Optimize in place of Condition, one Action, a relative wait, zero errors. Next: which test buttons send real email?